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Unravelling the Influence of Metaverse Fashion Marketing on Brand Image: Analyzing the Pros and Cons for Fashion Brands.

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This project is entirely the original work of the student registration number 33975531. I, Sakshi Khadgi declare that this dissertation is my work and that where material is obtained from published or unpublished works, this has been fully acknowledged in the references. This dissertation may include material from my work from a research proposal that has been previously submitted for assessment for this programme.

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Abstract

In today's digital age, where virtual and augmented reality technologies are gaining momentum, comprehending the potential of metaverse marketing is paramount. Metaverses, virtual realms crafted by users on platforms like Minecraft, Second Life, and Roblox, are becoming intriguing spaces for fashion brands to explore. This research investigates the strategies these companies employ within metaverse fashion marketing, focusing on the establishment of digital storefronts and participation in virtual events. It also evaluates the effectiveness of these strategies in shaping brand image and market presence.

Moreover, this study delves into the factors that optimize metaverse marketing for fashion brands, encompassing an in-depth examination of how brands leverage metaverses to showcase their products and core values. This includes creating digital stores and supporting various metaverse events. Additionally, it explores the influence of social and community dynamics on molding brand image within these immersive platforms. By shedding light on the application of metaverse marketing, this research offers valuable insights into the ever-evolving digital marketing and branding landscape, equipping marketers and researchers with the knowledge to craft effective strategies in this dynamic digital environment. The research, built on qualitative methods such as interviews and thematic analysis, aims to provide a nuanced understanding of this transformative marketing approach. Key findings include the potential for heightened consumer engagement compared to traditional digital marketing but also highlight cost constraints for many fashion brands and the niche nature of metaverse marketing, necessitating careful consideration of target demographics. It also identifies gaps in the existing literature, emphasizing the need for further exploration into socio-cultural factors influencing brand image within metaverses, thus benefiting academia and industry practitioners.

Keywords : Metaverse, Brand Image, Fashion, Marketing & Advertising, Consumer

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CHAPTER 01: INTRODUCTION

Background and Context

The contemporary digital landscape, characterized by the rapid development of virtual and augmented reality technologies, has brought about a notable shift in marketing strategies (Kaur & Singh, 2022). The shift has been greatly impacted by the rise of metaverses, which are captivating virtual worlds that blur the boundaries between reality and digital advancements in a natural manner. Metaverses can break down communication barriers and help companies connect with customers in new and profitable ways. Metaverses possess distinctive characteristics that enable them to foster robust emotional connections between corporations and customers (Stevenson, 2023), resulting in active exploration and authentic involvement.

Traditional advertising has limits, but metaverses offer a unique and unexplored space for innovative engagement, which encourages active discussion and goes beyond the constraints of traditional advertising. The emergence of metaverse-based marketing has substantially changed the advertising landscape, deviating from traditional methods (Bibri, 2023). This transition offers novel prospects as well as substantial challenges, requiring careful deliberation. As per a recent survey carried out by Statista, a considerable majority of participants, precisely 69%, foresee that augmented reality (AR) and virtual reality (VR) technologies will bring about a revolutionary change in consumer purchasing patterns (Rant, 2021).

One notable advantage of metaverses is their exceptional versatility, as they provide a conducive setting for innovative problem-solving by facilitating the convergence of fictional and actual elements. As a result of the present confluence of these two fields, organisations today have more ease in conveying their story and showcasing their fundamental principles via innovative means (Winquist et al., 2023). Based on a recent poll conducted by Deloitte, it has been suggested that the use of metaverse-based strategies has the capacity to enhance shopping experiences by making them

more enjoyable and engaging (Abraham and Khadaroo, 2021). Based on the findings of a consumer study, it was determined that a majority of 67 per cent of respondents saw augmented reality experiences as having a positive impact on the whole purchase process.

This phenomenon presents an opportunity to initiate a new phase of consumer-brand connection by strategically designing captivating and interactive experiences. According to Agustini et al. (2023), this strategy might be used to improve brand-consumer interactions in novel ways. However, it's important to remember that the metaverse isn't without its risks. Concerns about the privacy and security of personal information and the possibility of brand dilution as more entities join the metaverse are just a few of the issues that could arise because of the proliferation of virtual reality. The provision of distinctive consumer experiences, the development of brand loyalty, and the enhancement of the brand's reputation via creative practices are further benefits.

Research Rationale

Businesses now need to develop fresh approaches to attracting and keeping customers, considering the declining efficacy of traditional marketing channels and the growing importance of social media platforms in consumer engagement. Since the advent of metaverses, marketing has taken a significant step forward, allowing companies to successfully include clients in interactive interactions that go beyond the limitations of traditional advertising. There needs to be more studies on the efficacy of metaverse marketing despite its potential influence on brand-consumer interactions. Due to the ever-changing nature of the fashion industry, several companies have begun using metaverse platforms to increase brand awareness and client engagement.

There is a significant knowledge gap on the issue of fashion marketing in the metaverse and its effect on a company's reputation. Companies should leverage metaverses as a marketing tool and make educated decisions once the knowledge gap is closed.

Research Focus

This research aims to shed light on the intricate relationship between online fashion marketing and reputation management. We look at the pros and cons of using metaverse-based marketing strategies to promote fashion businesses in virtual worlds. Furthermore, this study aims to investigate the psychological aspects that contribute to the success of these methods, with a special emphasis on the role that social and community elements play in fostering a positive image of the business inside metaverses.

Aims and Objectives

The aim is to explore the advantages and disadvantages of fashion brands using the metaverse in their marketing strategies to enable brands to generate a positive brand image.

Objectives

- Determine how fashion companies are using the metaverse to promote their products in simulated environments.
- Focus on how the metaverse may help fashion companies build and strengthen their brands.
- Identify the potential disadvantages and challenges faced by fashion brands when utilizing the metaverse in their marketing strategies and assess their impact on brand image.
- Analyse case studies of fashion brands that have successfully used the metaverse in their marketing strategies to understand the key factors contributing to a positive brand image.
- Provide recommendations and guidelines for fashion brands on leveraging the metaverse in their marketing strategies to generate a positive brand image, considering the advantages, disadvantages, and consumer perceptions identified in the research.

Research Questions

How does fashion marketing in the metaverse impact brand image?

CHAPTER 02: LITERATURE REVIEW

The Emergence of the Metaverse and its Definition

The Metaverse was first described by Neal Stephenson in his novel 'Snow Crash' in 1992. It's a virtual reality-based successor to the internet, a digital space with multiple interconnected virtual reality environments (Kaplan & Haenlein, 2011). Based on the presented scenario, it is posited that virtual reality (VR) has the potential to serve as the fundamental basis of the internet in the future. This would result in the development of a vast digital realm wherein several VR experiences coexist harmoniously (Gibson, 2023). Within this ever-changing context, individuals engage in reciprocal communication with both their peers and the computer-generated surroundings, all in a synchronous manner.

This shift has empowered companies to establish more robust and intimate relationships with their clientele, surpassing previous boundaries and limitations (Vătămănescu and Mitan, 2023). Matthew Ball gives a detailed concept of the Metaverse in his book, "The Metaverse: and how it will revolutionize everything," along with an explanation of the technologies that will power it, the scientific advancements necessary to fully materialize it, and the governance challenges it brings. Additionally, he considers the virtually limitless applications of the Metaverse and foresees the development of new value amounting to trillions of dollars as well as a fundamental restructuring of society (Ball, 2022). The computer game "Fortnite," developed by Epic Games Inc. and Roblox Corp., showcases virtual concerts performed by renowned singers like Ariana Grande (as seen in Figure 1), exemplifying a project with significant transformational capabilities. The 2022 MTV Video Music Awards included a nomination for this event in the category of "Best Metaverse Performance."



Figure 1: Ariana Grande headlined Fortnite's interactive Rift Tour

(source: Jacob, Fortnite news, 2022)

Navigating Digital Transformation and Marketing in the Age of COVID-19 and Meta Verses

In the wake of the Covid-19 outbreak, enterprises have endeavored to digitally emulate customer-centric endeavours while maintaining their organizational personas. According to (Paganopoulos, 2022), it is asserted. Consequently, the marketing, digital, and sales departments assume more crucial functions and attribute significant importance to digital strategies and tactics. To sustain a competitive advantage, companies need to implement efficacious marketing tactics in the present day (Park et al., 2023). Many brands have not yet fully embraced this technology, as (Ravindran, 2022) noted, due to reservations about its cost and viability. I can understand their reluctance because investing in modern technologies can be costly, especially if there is doubt about their efficacy.

Moreover, the integration of Metaverses could necessitate additional resources, which some businesses may either be unwilling or financially unable to allocate at present (Clavería Camps, 2023).

Nevertheless, companies must recognize the potential impact that incorporating Metaverses into their marketing strategies could have on their overall business. The ongoing discourse regarding marketing within the Metaverse has ignited vigorous discussions among industry experts, primarily driven by concerns related to privacy in these digital realms. Users may exhibit hesitancy in sharing personal information or engaging in specific activities within these environments. Additionally, businesses must carefully contemplate how they intend to utilize the data gathered from user interactions. Despite these challenges, experts argue that Meta Verses have the potential to usher in a revolutionary shift in marketing practices (Park et al., 2023). This transformation is further propelled by the growing comfort of individuals with immersive online experiences, especially in the context of continued COVID-19 lockdowns. Consequently, brands are actively exploring avenues to integrate emerging technologies like VR or AR into their marketing campaigns.

Elevating Marketing Strategies:

Embracing Meta Verses for Lasting Customer Engagement

According to recent research conducted by (Langmia, 2023), it was observed that marketing activities centred on social media platforms have shown that amusing commercials can capture the attention of consumers and alleviate the perceived strain associated with reading such content. Nevertheless, it is important to consider that these commercials cannot foster client loyalty or generate repeat business. The integration of meta-verses offers a compelling option for addressing the limits associated with conventional techniques, promising enduring and substantial outcomes.

Given its potential for transformation, modern organizations should contemplate the use of Meta Verses in their marketing plans. According to the research conducted by Market Research Insights, it was observed that firms that used Meta Verses in their campaigns had a significant average rise of 45 per cent in consumer engagement measures, in contrast to those organisations that simply relied on traditional approaches (Alexander, 2021). The observed substantial rise in viewer engagement indicates that meta verses can connect with audiences at a basic level and elicit enduring

memories that extend beyond the original interaction. The attraction of Meta Verses plays a significant role in generating a lasting competitive advantage and driving sales growth. Based on the findings of FuturTech Insights, enterprises that successfully integrate Meta Verses into their operations see a notable 17% rise in sales conversion rates (Engel et al., 2022). The outcome may be attributed to heightened brand recognition and enhanced consumer satisfaction.

Furthermore, the use of Meta Verses has the potential to enhance brand loyalty (Barba-Kay, 2023). Based on recent research conducted by Consumer Insights Group, it was observed that organizations including Meta Verses in their marketing settings had a notable 32% rise in client retention rates during a one-year timeframe, in contrast to their counterparts who relied on traditional marketing techniques. This exemplifies the substantial influence that interactive engagements have on fostering consumer loyalty. To remain competitive in the contemporary marketing landscape, organizations need to use advanced techniques, including the utilization of Meta Verses (Selimi, 2022). The flexibility of these immersive platforms enables marketers to overcome the constraints associated with traditional advertising methods.

As an example, Coca-Cola demonstrated pioneering efforts in using the Metaverse platform via the development of an immersive virtual reality encounter titled "A Day in the Life of a Coke Bottle." The implementation of this novel approach facilitated consumers' understanding of intricate production and worldwide distribution procedures, resulting in a notable surge in website traffic (DAHIYA and Dahiya, 2023).

Exploring Technological Constraints and Promising Avenues:

Leveraging the Metaverse for Innovative Marketing Strategies

Deficiencies in current technological capabilities present a substantial barrier to achieving successful marketing strategies inside the metaverse. Establishing high-quality virtual environments requires significant expenditures in technological infrastructure and specialised knowledge.

Furthermore, marketers need to guarantee that the user experience is accessible to a wide range of individuals, perhaps requiring interoperability across several platforms and gadgets (Moin, 2022). The second problem lies in the development of captivating and gratifying experiences that resonate with customers. Businesses possess a distinct prospect to generate immersive and captivating encounters inside the metaverse; nevertheless, they must also devise innovative methods to involve customers within this unexplored domain actively.

One idea posits that the metaverse has the potential to provide consumers a feeling of community and belonging (Chow, 2020). The metaverse has the potential to create a feeling of community that surpasses traditional advertising methods by establishing digital platforms where customers may engage with both companies and other consumers. A potential association might exist between a heightened feeling of community and heightened levels of brand support and loyalty (Hauer, 2023). The metaverse has the capacity to foster a feeling of ownership and participation that is unattainable in the physical realm since it enables users to create and trade virtual items and services. The successful representation of brands in the metaverse has the potential to foster increased customer brand loyalty and connection (Paganopoulos, 2022). The word "metaverse" denotes a conceptual realm characterized by self-referentiality, whereby data may be sent over the internet and advanced software, ultimately creating an environment replicating the physical world's perceptual attributes.

By integrating them inside the metaverse, individuals have the opportunity to explore innovative methods of communication and explore items that include characteristics that are not present in the physical realm (Clavería Camps, 2023). Virtual reality (VR) and augmented reality (AR) technology allows individuals to participate in a virtual marketplace and engage with goods and brands in previously unattainable ways. As a result of the advanced capabilities of the metaverse, individuals have the opportunity to virtually engage with and explore various places, goods, and services that pique their interest, hence facilitating potential purchase decisions. The use of the metaverse inside a computer-generated three-dimensional (3D) environment has the potential to enhance the aesthetic

qualities of the physical world (Park et al., 2023). The use of avatars and holograms in virtual environments has facilitated simplified interaction, while the incorporation of advanced 5G technology allows users to actively engage with the meta space in a real-time manner. Several popular games, such as Second Life, Fortnite, Roblox, and VRChat, use virtual and immersive surroundings to enhance the overall gaming experience.

Customers may encounter a similar perception while engaging in the act of purchasing (Alexander, 2021). The use of the Metaverse has the potential to significantly facilitate the promotion of intangible services, including but not limited to consultancy, healthcare, and education. Advertising is a kind of communication that disseminates information to customers on the attributes, pricing, and accessibility of various items and services. The basic objective of advertising is to enhance customer knowledge of a certain service or product, and to generate sufficient interest that leads to consumer motivation for making a purchase (Barba-Kay, 2023). Marketers engage in communication with clients through using advertising as a medium and employing strategies that aim to evoke emotional responses. J.P (Engel et al., 2022). Morgan's research findings indicate that the metaverse offers companies the opportunity to effectively promote their goods to a global audience. Companies such as Nike and Coca-Cola have successfully built their own online communities. Prominent technology companies like as Apple, Meta, and Google are now engaged in competitive research pertaining to the metaverse.

Business enterprises allocate significant efforts towards the development of software that is interconnected with the metaverse. Metaverse has the capability to create a tailored gateway for enterprises, enabling their clientele to engage in an immersive virtual experience. Individuals have the ability to physically interact with and perceive the item, similar to the experience they would have at a brick-and-mortar retail establishment (Selimi, 2022). This arrangement allows firms to showcase their items throughout the metaverse. The potential enhancement of customers' brand impressions may occur when they are exposed to the immersive environment offered by the metaverse, which encompasses both utilitarian and hedonistic impacts along with a significant level of augmentation

(DAHIYA and Dahiya, 2023). Non-fungible tokens (NFTs) provide customers with the ability to acquire virtual items and properties that are safeguarded by blockchain technology, hence generating novel marketing prospects for virtual assets. Businesses often sponsor and employ live events and concerts as advertising outlets.

Exploring Business Implications:
Metaverse as a Platform for Brand-Consumer Interaction and Digital Fashion Revolution

The fundamental objective of Metaverse is to enhance the communication between organisations and consumers in a commercial context (Sundberg and Barnekow, 2022). This phenomenon may be attributed to the platform's capability of enabling users to create their own virtual identities and engage in simulated visits to diverse destinations. According to Johnson (2016), there has been a rise in the desire for individualised avatars. The phenomenon of individuals investing significant amounts of effort in the creation and customization of avatars inside virtual environments might potentially be elucidated via the lens of self-theory. Fashion, including digital fashion as well, has the potential to augment an individual's aesthetic appeal and captivate attention inside their digital milieu. In their study, Albers van der Linden (2022) examined the dynamics of user-avatar interactions, including both psychological and commercial dimensions. The investigation of the actualization and idealisation models of relationships has been conducted.

Both options have the potential to generate significant profits for fashion corporations. Considering the regularity with which consumers allocate their funds towards tangible acquisitions in order to fulfil a diverse range of requirements, desires, and expectations, it becomes imperative to ascertain the precise social and personal needs that digital fashion has the potential to cater to (De Filippi and Santolini, 2022). The possible negative effects of gaming have been explored in relation to the Maslow hierarchy of needs hypothesis, which posits that unfulfillment may be a contributing factor.A research conducted in the garment business has discovered many sustainable innovations,

including social media, digitalization, technical development, the circular economy, customization, artificial intelligence, and a concern for sustainability (Moin, 2022). The research suggests that the fashion business is characterised by a high level of competitiveness, which serves as a catalyst for its ongoing development and expansion.

Annually, new fashion trends incorporating technological elements are launched. Numerous luxury enterprises have already been using the prospects offered by the metaverse and artificial intelligence (AI) (Selimi, 2022). Noteworthy examples include Gucci, which has pioneered the development of the first virtual shoe, and Bvlgari, which has undertaken brand expansions via the utilisation of AI and NFT technology, among various other luxury corporations. According to (Gibson's, 2023), the fashion business has the potential to uncover new sources of income by means of increased information dissemination from academics and enhanced knowledge and skill acquisition by industry specialists. Digital fashion has the potential to serve as a viable zero-waste alternative for fashion firms, ultimately aligning with the fashion industry's overarching goal of achieving sustainability. According to Niinimaki et al. (2020), the fashion industry ranks as the second most environmentally detrimental sector globally, behind the oil industry.

According to the Ellen MacArthur Foundation's report in 2017, the worldwide market for textile waste is valued at over $500 billion on an annual basis (Vătămănescu and Mitan, 2023). Consequently, the Metaverse exhibits the capacity to facilitate cost savings for organisations and empower consumers in managing their impulsive buying tendencies. Due to the exigencies posed by the Metaverse and its associated technologies, it is certain that a fundamental transformation will be imperative for the fashion sector as a whole. Non-fungible tokens (NFTs) provide a range of user experiences including both digital and physical realms for consumers, staff engagement opportunities, the cultivation of Metaverses for cultural advancement and cooperation, and, naturally, the utilisation of NFTs themselves (Gibson's, 2023). NFTs can function as a platform for the promotion and enhancement of brand recognition. The destination of interest for the year 2022 is Bali. Enterprises are now engaged in the process of strategizing how to generate financial gains inside the digital

realms, which possess significant untapped opportunities for future growth. The focal point of marketing inside the metaverse revolves on the whole client journey.

Hence, it is essential for all marketing strategies to prioritise the enhancement of the client experience. When formulating marketing interventions for the metaverse, marketers place emphasis on key factors such as immersion, social involvement, and the creation of genuine environments (Vătămănescu and Mitan, 2023). The extent to which one may engage in an immersive experience inside the metaverse is reliant upon the integration of embedded technologies, namely those that provide the seamless merging of virtual and physical surroundings. The setup and features of a telepresence system are crucial factors that contribute to the level of immersion experienced by users. Augmented reality (AR) projects that prioritise social interaction has the capacity to significantly transform consumer preferences and behavior (Ohashi et al., 2023). The term "environmental fidelity" in the context of the metaverse refers to the faithfulness or accuracy with which the virtual environment replicates the physical world.

The existing body of marketing literature primarily examines the influence of customers' varied aims on their purchasing behaviour within diverse metaverse situations. Further investigation has shown that the fashion sector will have challenges in the production and marketing of its products due to technology breakthroughs, such as the metaverse (Paganopoulos, 2022). The metaverse as a novel platform business model offers a multitude of advantages, including enhanced productivity, economic growth, improved transparency, sustainability, heightened security, and increased safety. The business models for product platforms are finally achieved via the many links and interfaces in the digital realm. Manufacturers and merchants are actively engaged in the creation of digital counterparts, taking into consideration the preferences and expectations of Generation Z as an educated customer base in the future (Recanati, 2023). The marketing strategies used inside the metaverse for the fashion sector comprise a comprehensive range of activities pertaining to the digital fashion company. These activities include brand management, online communication, and electronic commerce. The integration of further modifications in this domain will provide a substantial influence on marketing

tactics when coupled with the advancements in metaverse technology (Vătămănescu and Mitan, 2023).

The fashion sector in the metaverse is primarily built around the concept of virtual transformation, whereby the utilisation of digital pictures, videos, and augmented reality films serves as a means to distribute virtual garments and accessories. Based on a recent research, virtual clothes designers get influence from both conventional garment designers and their digital counterparts. According to studies, a wide range of virtual and augmented reality technologies are often used in various kinds of the metaverse (Langmia, 2023). By using augmented reality technology, it becomes possible to visually overlay garments over the user's body. This solution combines the functionalities of augmented reality for 3D product visualisation with virtual mirror technology. The use of augmented reality technology, such as 3D product views and virtual mirrors, has the potential to enhance the online purchase experience, making it more closely resemble the traditional in-store shopping experience (Engel et al., 2022).

An example of virtual reality implementation within the fashion business is the use of avatars in digital fitting rooms accessible through internet platforms. Avatars serve as a prominent illustration of how fashion is used inside the metaverse, since they augment the appealing attributes of commercial goods. Similarly, virtual changing rooms improve the customer experience by providing novelty and facilitating the exploration of new possibilities. The development of this theoretical contribution is of utmost importance, namely in the identification of pivotal individuals who will shape the trajectory of the fashion sector inside the metaverse (Moin, 2022).

The Tech Developers

The entities with the necessary resources and skills to provide material for the metaverse include various organisations, groups, and governmental bodies. While individuals possess the freedom to seek employment with any organisation, the primary emphasis of this essay is in exploring the potential enhancement of online fashion marketing via their skill sets (Albers van der Linden, 2022). In parallel to the function of an online designer in facilitating the establishment of businesses' online presence, we see the increasing responsibilities of technology developers as a means for fashion enterprises to access the metaverse. Nike formed a strategic alliance with Roblox to establish Nikeland (Figure 2), Burberry collaborated with Mythical Games to launch their Blankos Block Party campaign (figure3), and Balenciaga showcased their Fall 2021 collection in a virtual exhibition within the popular video game Fortnite (De Filippi and Santolini, 2022). These programmers might serve as the foundation for developing video games.



Figure 2: Nikeland

(source: Luke Hinton, gfinity esports, 2022)



Figure 3: Burberry collaborated with Mythical Games to launch their Blankos Block Party campaign

(source: Burberry,2022)



Figure 4: Balenciaga showcased their Fall 2021 collection in a virtual exhibition within the popular video game Fortnite

(Source: epicgames, 2021)

Developers may include both corporate entities and individual practitioners. As an example, it is worth noting that Mike Winkelmann, a digital artist well known as Beeple, contributed to the commemoration of Louis Vuitton's 200th anniversary by donating non-fungible tokens (NFTs). Advertising firms, like RNO1, Coinbound, Publicis Poke, and Rumfoords, are actively using Web 3.0, the metaverse, and artificial intelligence to aid companies in creating a robust presence inside the metaverse. According to a study conducted by (Sundberg and Barnekow, 2022), which outlined the top Metaverse Marketing Agencies in 2023, there exist many prospects for companies to engage in collaborative efforts with these agencies to develop pioneering projects inside the unexplored realm of the metaverse.

Fashion Brands

Fashion brands in the business are eager to organise virtual fashion shows, engage in online promotion of their latest collections, and establish strategic partnerships with other enterprises. The collaborative effort between Burberry and Mythical Games resulted in the creation of Blankos Block Party (figure3). The NFT vinyl figurines integrated into the blockchain infrastructure represent a constituent aspect of a fashion-centric, expansive, multiplayer metaverse video game. The metaverse has significant prospects for the prosperity of fashion enterprises, so dispelling the notion that it only caters to luxury sectors (Ravindran, 2022).

The availability of NFTs for BoohooMAN's latest collection of T-shirts, sweatshirts, tracksuits, and outerwear allows clients to update their virtual stock comprehensively. Leverage the proficiency of software engineers to build a prominent presence inside the metaverse. To operationalize the metaverse marketing notion, it is essential for fashion firms' designers, marketers, and creative directors to engage in collaborative efforts with programmers (Chow, 2020). When two fashion firms that are similarly similar do not possess the necessary means to independently manufacture a product, it is this particular kind of cooperation that often sets them apart.

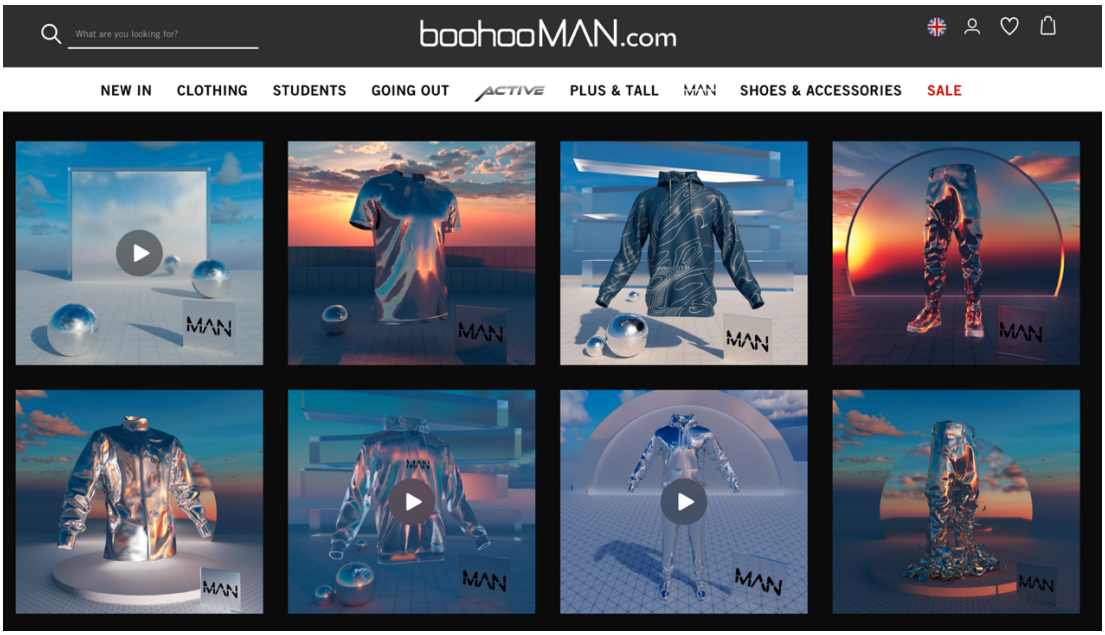


Figure 5: Screenshot from Boohoomen website- NFTs collection.

(source: boohooman.com)

This literature review on the metaverse's influence on fashion marketing provides valuable insights, but it is essential to acknowledge its limitations. Firstly, the review relies on existing literature, which may not capture the rapidly evolving nature of the metaverse. Additionally, the metaverse's impact can vary significantly across industries and marketing strategies, making it challenging to provide a comprehensive analysis. Furthermore, ethical concerns, especially related to data privacy and user protection, require more in-depth exploration. The review predominantly reflects Western markets and may not fully account for regional and cultural variations in the adoption and impact of metaverse marketing. Lastly, there's a limited focus on how small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) can effectively utilize the metaverse for marketing, which is an area ripe for further investigation. Addressing these limitations through empirical research will contribute to a more nuanced understanding of the metaverse's role in shaping the future of fashion marketing.

CHAPTER 03: METHODOLOGY

This chapter gives an in-depth description of the methodology used to analyze the results of Metaverse fashion marketing on brand image. The value of qualitative research lies in allowing researchers to delve deeply into the topic at hand. Professionals in marketing and fashion may provide invaluable insight into how the metaverse affects brand perception, and interviews are a great way to tap into their knowledge. Each interview took around 30 minutes on average and was conducted through video conferencing technology. The interview questionnaire covers a wide variety of topics, from basic metaverse understanding to the effect of the medium on brand recognition.

The analysis of interview transcripts included the use of thematic coding in order to detect reoccurring themes and patterns (Agustini et al., 2023). Throughout each phase of the study, ethical considerations played a vital role in safeguarding the rights and well-being of participants. These considerations included obtaining informed permission, preserving anonymity, upholding stringent privacy protocols and understanding the various constraints that may be connected with qualitative research (Abraham & Khadaroo, 2021). Notwithstanding these constraints, this approach thoroughly analyses the subject matter.

This research study has undergone the ethical review and approval process, represented by ERGO (Ethical et al.) form number 56206. This rigorous ethical review process ensures that the research adheres to established ethical standards and safeguards the rights and well-being of participants involved in the study. It includes comprehensive assessments of the research methodology, data collection, participant consent, and data handling procedures to guarantee that the research is conducted with integrity, fairness, and ethical considerations. The approval obtained through this process signifies that the research has met the ethical requirements and is conducted in an ethically responsible manner.

Research Design

The selection of a qualitative methodology for this research stems from its innate capacity to navigate the intricate web of individuals' perceptions, attitudes, and experiences, aligning seamlessly with the overarching research objective of exploration and discovery. Qualitative research provides an optimal framework for comprehending the multifaceted mechanisms at play within the Metaverse. It empowers the researcher to delve into the subtle nuances and underlying factors that shape the perception of brand impressions in this dynamic digital realm.

In harmony with the investigative nature of this study, the qualitative methodology offers a unique opportunity to gain profound insights into individual experiences and diverse viewpoints (Kingstone et al., 2020). The interviews, characterized by open-ended questions, foster an environment conducive to honest and uninhibited dialogue, encouraging participants to share their thoughts openly. This approach goes beyond surface-level responses, allowing for the exploration of ideas, movements, and emotions, thereby enriching the narrative constructed through interviews and significantly enhancing the depth of inquiry.

Data Collection

During the data collection phase, the conduct of in-depth interviews assumed a pivotal role in gathering valuable insights. The interviewees comprised seasoned experts within the realms of fashion marketing and management, ensuring a rich diversity of perspectives and experiences. Employing a semi-structured interview format added a layer of consistency to the sessions, offering a balanced mix of guided and spontaneous conversations. These interviews served as a comprehensive exploration into various facets of the metaverse, encompassing participants' comprehension of this digital realm, their perceptions of its impact on brand image, the challenges they encountered, and the strategies they employed to navigate it effectively. The organized and systematic nature of these interviews facilitated the extraction of a wide spectrum of viewpoints, shedding light on how the

metaverse was poised to reshape the intricate landscape of fashion marketing (Infante and Mardikaningsih, 2022).

Data Analysis

The application of a thematic analysis approach was executed with precision and diligence, serving as an indispensable tool for guiding the research process effectively (Kingstone et al., 2020). The researchers adhered to a rigorous thematic coding methodology, systematically categorizing the unfiltered and authentic expressions shared by the participants during the interviews.

This meticulous process led to the identification and meticulous organization of numerous themes, which could be likened to the harmonious components of a symphony coming together. As these individual codes converged, they gave rise to overarching themes, unveiling subtle yet profound patterns that provided invaluable insights into the study's intricate landscape (Rahmatika et al., 2021). This systematic thematic analysis approach ensured that the research findings were rooted in a robust and comprehensive understanding of the data, thus enhancing the study's credibility and reliability.

Ethical Considerations

Moral ideals played a fundamental role as steadfast pillars throughout the investigation. The dedication to upholding ethical integrity was readily apparent and nurtured by the foundational principles of rigorous research technique (Kingstone et al., 2020). The highest-ranking criterion on the list was the acquisition of permission via mutual understanding between the researcher and the participant. The interviewees demonstrated complete transparency about the study's aims and their entitlements as participants. Pseudonyms safeguard anonymity, acting as a shield for one's identity, while secure data storage repositories ensure the preservation of secrecy. The proliferation of social media analysis inside the digital realm has given rise to ethical considerations (Rahmatika et al., 2021).

The comprehensive but courteous investigation was restricted to documents that are readily available to the public, so safeguarding individuals' privacy and refraining from accessing sensitive information without their explicit consent (Matamoros-Fernández and Farkas, 2021). The process of doing research involves navigating through many restrictions while maintaining ethical principles.

Limitations

While acknowledging the valuable contributions of qualitative insights to this research, it's crucial to recognize and appreciate the inherent limitations associated with this approach. Despite conducting comprehensive interviews to gain a deep understanding of the qualitative landscape, it's important to acknowledge that such an approach may not encompass all possible viewpoints and perspectives (Herawati et al., 2022).

The process of forming assessments based on qualitative data is subject to a degree of influence from individual biases and personal experiences. These subjective factors can subtly shape the outcomes and interpretations derived from the research, highlighting the need for a nuanced consideration of the findings. One noteworthy aspect that has been instrumental in this research is the ethical dimension. Ethical considerations have played a pivotal role in guiding the trajectory of knowledge acquisition. The commitment to ethical principles and practices has ensured that the pursuit of knowledge remains on a moral and responsible path. This ethical stance has helped in upholding the integrity and credibility of the research.

Despite the presence of methodological limitations, it is important to underscore that ethics has been a guiding light throughout this research journey. The subsequent chapter will delve into the findings, intricately exploring the ethical nuances intertwined with the impact of Metaverse fashion marketing on brand perception (Abraham and Khadaroo, 2021). These findings will provide a comprehensive understanding of the complex interplay between ethical considerations and the evolving landscape of Metaverse marketing.

CHAPTER 04: RESULTS

In this chapter, we'll look at what was learned via extensive, in-depth interviews with seasoned professionals in the fashion sector. The interviews expertly show how much of an effect Metaverse fashion marketing has on consumer attitudes towards brands. Information gleaned from these talks has been expertly structured thematically, allowing for a close inspection of the study's core components. This method of presentation reveals the intricacy of the subject at hand and offers a complete picture. This chapter demystifies the intricate relationships between the Metaverse, fashion marketing, and the dynamics of brand image via the thematic structuring of interview data.

Defining the Metaverse and its Opportunities for Brands

When the replies were analyzed considering the metaverse's possible impact on fashion marketing and businesses, a common thread of opinion emerged from the participants. These findings reaffirmed the idea that the metaverse is a huge, linked virtual realm that exists independently of physical location.

All those who took part agreed that the virtual world is a great place for fashion companies to try out radical new forms of expression that would be impossible in the physical world. Participants saw the metaverse's potential for interactive marketing, which would allow organizations to forge more meaningful connections with their target audiences. It was expected that this would help the company connect with its consumers on an emotional level, which would ultimately lead to increased sales. In addition, the participants praised the metaverse for its potential as a place to share stories beyond traditional advertising.

Barriers Hindering Engagement with the Metaverse

An overarching theme of "newness" evolved; however, this may be both a strength and a weakness in the metaverse. Few participants concurred that people would be reluctant to enter this unfamiliar digital space since it requires a different perspective on marketing. "Uncertainty about return on investment (ROI)" appeared as a major motif in one of the participant's interviews.

The technology landscape posed both insurmountable opportunities and challenges. Participants confirmed the technological challenges and difficulties of taking part in the metaverse. The need for cutting-edge technical expertise and the skill to successfully traverse complex technological environments may be daunting for firms, especially those with less experience around digital innovation. One argued that only the brands who are well established can get on board with Metaverse, whereas the other participant pointed out that there are a lot of upcoming brands who started their journey by stepping into the pool of Metaverse by giving an example of a new brand called 'Fetus'(Elaborated In the presentation in appendix). Specifically, one person thought that their "target audience might not be present in the metaverse." This point of view establishes a firm boundary, exposing the worries of certain fashion businesses over the tastes and behaviors of their internet clientele.

Transformative Shifts in Fashion Marketing Dynamics

Their distinct perspectives served to accentuate a notable distinction between the well-established techniques of conventional advertising and the uncharted territories of the metaverse. The uniqueness of the metaverse as a place for increased human involvement, interaction, and sensory wonders may be traced back to its genetic makeup. According to a participant, its intrinsic transformational potential sets this metaverse apart from traditional marketing settings. Taking part in virtual activities in the metaverse makes them seem more progressive than they really are. A participant pointed out a major difference in digital versus metaverse marketing by quoting, "digital marketing is pretty much either still imagery or videos, so that doesn't involve as much engagement

from a consumer point of view." Whereas the metaverse has more engagement of the users, they quoted, "a person would feel way more involved than they would say looking at a photo shoot in a magazine or they would be looking at a website for that matter."

Challenges, Strategies, and Brand Image Impact

The discussion surrounding the convergence of the metaverse's allure with the imperative need for individual privacy underscored a critical aspect of this research. One participant articulated the paramount importance of safeguarding user privacy in the metaverse. This viewpoint resonates deeply in a digital age where concerns about personal data and online privacy have come under intense scrutiny. The participant passionately emphasized the necessity of preventing any breaches of user privacy within the metaverse environment. This not only involves protecting sensitive user information but also extends to cultivating user trust through the provision of user-friendly, error-free interfaces. Transparency and clarity in intentions were also highlighted as crucial elements to establish trust and reassure users about their privacy.

However, it is imperative to recognize that the relevance and solutions to these privacy-related challenges transcend their immediate application within the metaverse. The broader digital landscape faces ongoing debates and dilemmas concerning user privacy, data protection, and ethical practices in the digital sphere. Consequently, addressing these issues in the context of the metaverse represents a microcosm of the larger discussions surrounding privacy and ethics in the digital era.

Virtual Fashion and Influencers: Exploring New Frontiers

The rise of virtual fashion and influencers ushers in a new age of creativity in the vast, all-encompassing metaverse (Firdaus and Afdholy, 2023). The findings that resulted from the participants provided striking illumination into the intricate web of relationships between originality, credibility, and public perception of a brand. Virtual fashion provides marketers with a platform to try daring new ideas in a world where fantasy and reality blend together. As the discussion progressed, it was clear that the attendees understood that virtual fashion is about more than just wearing ethereal clothing; it's also about wrapping the brand in a creative vision that appeals to a tech-savvy demographic.

They stressed the significance of harmonizing these digital representations' ideals with the brand's core values. One of the participants gave an example of the meta-influencer Lil Miquela (seen in figure 06) and Fortnite x Travis Scott, a virtual concert experience within the game, the well-known online video game Fortnite teamed up with musician Travis Scott in April 2020 (Figure 07).



Figure 6: LilMiquela feactured in the Business of Fashion under 'Fashion's First Computer-Generated Influencer

(Source: Courtesy, business of fashion, 2018)



Figure 7: Fortnite x Travis Scott

(source: Palmer Haasch, Insider, 2020)

Visual Identity, Metrics, and Analytics

A participant stressed on the importance of visual identity as more than just a pretty face; it acts as a beacon to help customers find their way across the whole experience. A brand's color palette, logo, and visual language all work together to provide an immediate feeling of comfort and "this is us." Strong visual identity helps customers find their way across the enormous metaverse, where the virtual and real coexist. They provided an example of the three white stripes for Adidas.

Metrics like user engagement, interaction length, social sharing, and sentiment analysis take center stage when one of the participant's insights is revealed. Analytics technologies, such as Google Analytics and social media insights, were lauded by participants for their ability to shed light on users' behaviours, interactions, and preferences.

Ethical Considerations in Metaverse Marketing

The participants shed light on the rules that fashion firms must follow in this online realm, illuminating a righteous way forward despite the endless possibilities. They argue that welcoming all perspectives is essential to successful online communication. Companies in the fashion industry were urged to make their online communities accessible and inclusive to people of all ages, races, and abilities.

A participant suggested that businesses proceed with care, steer clear of harmful preconceptions, and use a wide range of personalities that accurately represent their target audiences. They stressed the need to maintain a hostile-free zone in this linked physical and intangible environment.

CHAPTER 05: DISCUSSION

Through a rich tapestry of insights gleaned from in-depth interviews with industry insiders, the preceding chapter shed light on the complicated links between brand image and Metaverse fashion marketing. Following this overview and analysis of these findings, we will go more deeply into their implications, linkages, and wide application in both academic and industrial realms.

The realizations derived from this research are interwoven with the myriad possibilities that the metaverse offers to forward-thinking enterprises eager to harness its dynamism. One particularly notable similarity that emerges is the potential for crafting comprehensive brand experiences that transcend the conventional constraints imposed by physical venues (Dwivedi et al., 2023).

The metaverse's remarkable attribute of seamlessly traversing geographical borders presents a compelling proposition for marketers. This unique feature encourages businesses to capitalize on the medium's accessibility to reach a truly global audience (Thaichon et al., 2022). Unlike physical locations, the metaverse erases the limitations of physical distance, making it possible for brands to connect with consumers across the world instantaneously. This global reach opens up new avenues for brand exposure and customer engagement.

Furthermore, the metaverse's capacity to facilitate the creation of elaborate and immersive narratives around products or services is another striking feature. This capability implies that businesses may have the opportunity to subtly influence consumers' opinions and perceptions (Peredo Alarcon, 2023). By carefully crafting these narratives, brands can guide customers through engaging and interactive experiences that not only inform but also shape their understanding and preferences.

In essence, the metaverse empowers businesses to transcend the conventional boundaries of physical marketing and enter a realm where global accessibility and immersive storytelling converge. These unique qualities of the metaverse offer innovative avenues for brand promotion and engagement, marking a paradigm shift in contemporary marketing strategies.

Barriers Hindering Engagement with the Metaverse

Many fashion companies are reluctant to embrace the metaverse because it is completely unexplored ground, and other brands are hesitant because of unclear intentions and multiple challenges involved (Stringfield, 2022). Challenges include not having the necessary technical knowledge, not knowing how much of a return on investment (ROI) to expect, and not being comfortable with this new digital frontier (Coppola, 2022). Since the metaverse is a place for technical innovation and creative experimentation, its direct influence on financial outcomes may be hard to quantify, as participants confessed. Brands often have second thoughts about investing in metaverse projects because of the uncertainty around the monetary value produced from such projects (Parialò, 2022).

There is also worry that their intended audience may not be present in the virtual world. The relevance of these results is that they serve as a call to action for enterprises to not only realize the promise of the metaverse, but also address these problems strategically, therefore overcoming these impediments (Narwal et al., 2022). The metaverse is a fascinating arena of possibilities, but it may require more traction before it becomes a staple of every consumer's digital diet.

Transformative Shifts in Fashion Marketing Dynamics

Marketers are using the metaverse as a platform to create avant-garde narratives in the form of interactive storytelling for their target demographic (van Doorn et al., 2021). The metaverse's meteoric rise to the forefront of the fashion marketing industry has signaled a shocking departure from more traditional avenues. Experience marketing is king in this setting because user engagement is elevated to an "active" state (Yan, 2023). This shift in marketing strategy creates a more intimate connection between companies and their clients in the virtual world. The association will boost the company's profile by demonstrating its commitment to cutting-edge technology. Businesses are able

to demonstrate their resilience in the face of constant change by adapting to the metaverse, which influences how customers see and engage with them (Ohashi et al., 2023).

Challenges, Strategies, and Brand Image Impact

The metaverse may have limitless opportunities but has its fair share of challenges. The participants highlighted technology problems, worries about personal data, and the possibility of a backlash. To overcome these challenges, companies need to create long-term strategies that priorities customers' personal information, provide frictionless interactions, and ensure clear objectives. A brand's reputation in the metaverse might be damaged if these problems aren't addressed. Thus, preventative measures should be taken with care to protect the brand's long-term viability (Abraham and Khadaroo, 2021). The public may see technical failures as a lack of care, consumers may doubt the integrity of companies in response to privacy issues, and critics may sow the seeds of distrust via blowback. From this vantage point, it is quite evident that challenges are more than just stumbling blocks; they are integral players in the story of the brand's reputation (Dwivedi et al., 2023). Ignoring them is the same as ignoring the potential for waves of dissatisfaction and doubt to spread over the Internet. Consistency across issues, approaches, and the brand's public persona is essential for preserving its rising pitch of resonance.

Virtual Fashion and Influencers: Exploring New Frontiers

The rise of virtual fashion and influencers ushers in a new age of creativity in the vast, all-encompassing metaverse (Firdaus and Afdholy, 2023). The metaverse has evolved into a fertile ground for the confluence of virtual fashion and influencers. These groups emerged as ports of entry into unexplored waters, providing companies with the tools they needed to make ideas a reality (Calzada, 2022). The views expressed by the participants were in accordance with what we mean when we talk about authenticity, which is when the ideals of a company and the philosophy of its online

influencers are in harmony. As a result of the interplay between trust and innovation, companies operating in this space may give their brands a distinctive and lasting impression (Danielsson and Westrup, 2023).

Brand values and online influencers need to align in the same way that the stars need to align to create a celestial masterpiece if they are to produce a genuine and interesting tale to readers. This new level of brand-consumer relationships is the result of a dynamic force brought about by the online influencers' symphony of authenticity and creativity (García Díaz, 2023). This ethereal backdrop gives the brand-image narrative a new beat. The story of the brand is enhanced by virtual fashion and influencers. The metaverse serves as a canvas for companies to build a futuristic and true portrayal of themselves because of its adaptable forms and limitless innovation.

Visual Identity, Metrics, and Analytics

The idea of visual identity materializes like a stroke of a paintbrush, laying the groundwork for lasting brand awareness in the intricate fabric of the metaverse, where pixels twirl in a dazzling display of originality (Vătămănescu and Mitan, 2023). In today's digital age, however, simple visuals may be converted into actionable data points that can be utilized to gauge the success of a company's metaverse marketing campaigns.

In the vastness of cyberspace, the quest for a unique visual identity was akin to following the beacon of a lighthouse (Rathore, 2020). Metrics tracked expedition components including interaction, sentiment, and engagement to create a triangular diagram of brand resonance. The speakers stressed the importance of analytics tools as digital compasses that help organizations navigate the ever-changing currents of the metaverse, enhance resonance, and fine-tune their strategy (Pizzi and Ligorio, 2023).

Ethical Considerations in Metaverse Marketing

The infinite possibilities of the metaverse called for an unwavering dedication to moral duty. The guiding principles were based on the same values that are held in the real world, such as accountability, openness, and respect for variety (Snoeck and Neerman, 2022). The comments provided insight into the route, which highlighted the role firms played in shaping not just experiences but also morals and ethics. The safe haven of the metaverse was meant to be a reflection of the real world, with all of its beauty, variety, and respect. Input from users acted as a compass for this development, leading to a metaverse that was representative of a wide range of human ideals (Vikram and Sood, 2022).

A participant recommended that firms move forward in a careful, stress-free environment. Companies that do this encourage customers to interact with them more intimately and become into symbols of empowerment (Dwivedi et al., 2023). By interacting with consumers and adjusting to the dynamic metaverse, brands can raise their moral standing.

CHAPTER 06: CONCLUSION

Metaverse marketing represents a groundbreaking opportunity for businesses to revolutionize their marketing strategies and influence customer behaviour in unprecedented ways. The limitless potential of the metaverse opens new avenues for brands to differentiate themselves and leave a lasting impression on their customers. Implementing metaverse marketing could increase sales, heighten brand awareness, and enhance consumer loyalty. However, it is crucial to acknowledge that metaverse marketing carries certain risks and drawbacks along with its promises. One of the critical advantages of metaverse marketing is the ability to provide customers with memorable and thrilling virtual experiences. These experiences can captivate audiences in ways that traditional marketing methods cannot. Such immersive experiences can lead to higher engagement, deeper emotional connections with the brand, and, ultimately, more significant returns on investment.

Nevertheless, it is essential to exercise caution in the metaverse marketing landscape. Potential pitfalls include privacy concerns, unrealistic expectations, and the challenge of targeting the right audience. Privacy issues can arise as customers engage with brands in virtual spaces, and managing data ethically becomes paramount. Unrealistic expectations may surface as the novelty of the metaverse wears off, leading to potential disillusionment among consumers. Additionally, failing to identify and engage the correct audiences within the vast metaverse ecosystem can result in wasted resources and missed opportunities.

Therefore, businesses should approach metaverse marketing with a strategic mindset. It is imperative to proceed with caution and a thorough understanding of this emerging platform's benefits and challenges. Collaborating with immersive technology and virtual reality specialists is crucial to creating extraordinary metaverse experiences that meet and exceed customer expectations.

Furthermore, the dynamic nature of the metaverse requires continuous evaluation and adaptation of marketing tactics. Brands must consistently assess the alignment of their metaverse strategies with their overarching marketing goals and be prepared to make constructive alterations

based on customer behaviour and feedback. In doing so, businesses can harness the full potential of the metaverse to enhance their marketing efforts and drive sustainable success in this evolving digital landscape.

Limitations

Despite the valuable insights offered by this research, it's important to acknowledge certain limitations. While the qualitative approach employed here excels in storytelling and capturing nuanced experiences, it may fall short in the intricate and multifaceted landscape of the metaverse. One noteworthy limitation is the potential influence of a researcher's own preconceptions and experiences on how they interpret the collected data. This subjectivity could introduce bias into the analysis.

Additionally, there are inherent limitations related to data collection and processing. These limitations might unintentionally result in the exclusion of complex and diverse perspectives from the study. In such a dynamic and rapidly evolving environment as the metaverse, it's essential to exercise constant vigilance to ensure that the principles of diversity, inclusiveness, and ethical standards are upheld. To address these methodological limitations, future research endeavors should delve more deeply into the intricate relationship between metaverse marketing and brand image. By employing a more comprehensive and diverse set of research methods, researchers can better capture the multifaceted nature of this emerging field. Furthermore, a combination of qualitative and quantitative approaches could help mitigate subjectivity and provide a more holistic understanding of the impact of metaverse marketing on brand image. These refinements will contribute to more robust and insightful research in this evolving domain.

Recommendations

To embark on a comprehensive analysis of the influence of metaverse fashion marketing on brand image, it's imperative to establish a strategic framework that aligns with your brand's core values and marketing objectives. This foundation will set you apart from competitors by ensuring your metaverse projects prioritize customer needs and deliver innovative, distinctive solutions. To enhance your metaverse initiatives, it's advisable to collaborate with experts who can contribute to technological advancements, maintain ethical standards, and guide the creation of user-generated content. Employ analytics rigorously to monitor results and make necessary adjustments along the way. Effective risk management, clear communication, and robust training protocols are vital for fostering user trust within the metaverse. Embrace a long-term perspective to adeptly navigate the dynamic consequences of metaverse marketing on customer perceptions and behaviors. This holistic approach ensures a comprehensive understanding of the metaverse's impact on fashion brand image.

APPENDICES

Appendix 1 : Recruitment Email

Research Title: To investigate the Influence of Metaverse Fashion Marketing on Brand Image: Analyzing the Pros and Cons for Fashion Brands

Dear (name of participant)
My name is Sakshi Khadgi, and I am writing this email to ask you if you would like to participate in my research study about fashion in the Metaverse.
I am a master's student at University of Southampton, Winchester School of Art, studying Fashion Management. This research is my final major project for my Master's degree. The Faculty Ethics Committee has approved the research; ERGO number 56206.
I would like to interview you about your experience working with fashion in the Metaverse. I you are agreeable, I would like to interview you online for around 20-30 minutes. I can inform you of the interview questions beforehand so you may be prepared. You will need to give your permission for the interviews to be recorded and transcribed into English, if necessary.
Interviews will be arranged at a convenient time in the period from 23rd June to 23rd July using Microsoft Teams or Zoom.
Please can you confirm your participation by contacting me by
email: sk2n22@soton.ac.uk
Thank you, for your co-operation and time; this is much appreciated.
If you know any other fashion designers who you think would be happy to be interviewed for this research, please feel free to forward this message to them.

Appendix 2 : ERGO form

University of Southampton

Research Ethics Form for:
MA Fashion Management Final Project ARTD 6125

OPTION B: Logging PGT Projects which require Ethics review

Name: Sakshi Khadgi
Student ID number: 33975531
Student email address: sk2n22@soton.ac.uk
Supervisor name: Charlie Ellis
Programme of study (Module Code): PAS 2

Project title: To investigate how fashion is being created in the Metaverse and how fashion brands are using the metaverse to promote their image and products.
Project research aim and research questions:
AIM: The aim is to explore the advantages and disadvantages for fashion brands using the metaverse in their marketing strategies to enable brands to generate positive brand image.
Research Question: How does fashion marketing in the metaverse impact brand image?

SECTION 1

Does your research fall within the guidance for the Module level approval?
YES☒ Tick here and continue below. **NO** ☐ Tick here and go straight to Section 4 on this form. Sign DECLARATION B and discuss a separate ERGO ethics application with your supervisor.

Please tick all the boxes for research methods you will use and then provide the required information in the pages below
☑ Interviews
☐ Focus groups
☐ Questionnaire (online)
☑ Analysis of Social Media Data

SECTION 2

Section 2.1 Interviews

You can do interviews in-person (in a public space where it can be assumed that there are appropriate Health and Safety procedures in place) or online (e.g. using Microsoft Teams or WeChat). When doing interviews, you must use a participant information sheet and a consent form. See the guidance for interviews (online) and guidance for interviews (in-person) in the *Guidance to Students*.

Answer the following questions:

What information will you gather using your interviews?
Answer- It is anticipated that qualitative data will be collected, encompassing pertinent marketing knowledge and first-hand accounts from industry experts working on the metaverse in fashion.

What group of participants will you target for the interviews?
Answer- Industry experts and Influencers.

How many participants do you plan to recruit?
Answer- maximum 10 participants.

Will the interviews be online / in-person
Answer- Online.

If online, will interviews be conducted on Microsoft Teams
Answer- Microsoft Teams

How long do you expect each interview to last?
Answer- 20 to 30 mins each

What method are you using to recruit participants for interviews (online)?

Only tick the platforms you will be using.

☑ Direct email to someone I already know
☑ Facebook group/direct message
☐ LinkedIn group/direct message
☐ Twitter public tweet/direct message
☐ Weibo public post/direct message
☐ Whatsapp group/direct message
☐ WeChat group/direct message

Recruitment Email

Re: To investigate how fashion is being created in the Metaverse and how fashion brands are using the metaverse to promote their image and products.

Hi there, myself Sakshi Khadgi and I am writing this email to inform you about an opportunity to participate in an independent research study regarding fashion in the metaverse.
This study will be conducted at Winchester School of Art, University of Southampton as a part of my Masters of Fashion Management thesis project.
If you choose to participate, you will be asked to perform in a 20-30-minute-long online interview.
Please feel to contact me at sk2n22@soton.ac.uk for additional information.
Thank you for your consideration and once again, please do not hesitate to contact me.

Sincerely,

Sakshi Khadgi,
Master of Fashion Managements
Studies University of Southampton
sk2n22@soton.ac.uk

Please read the following statements carefully and tick all boxes to confirm that you have understood

☑ I confirm that I will use the included recruitment message templates, edited to match my participant recruitment plans. Add where it can be found as a document
☑ I confirm that I will use the included participant information sheet for the interviews, edited to match my research.
☑ I confirm that I use the included consent form for the interviews, edited to match my research.
☑ I confirm that I will inform all participants that I will audio/video record the interviews (and will not record them unless they have given written consent.
☑ I confirm that I have read the instructions and restrictions for interviews and that my research project will conform with these.
☑ Only I will have access to the non-anonymous data
☑ Only I and my supervisor will have access to the anonymized data
☑ I understand that if I lose personal data, I must contact databreach@soton.ac.uk immediately.
☑ I will use the University of Southampton's OneDrive as the only data storage for all data gathered during the research.

☑ Data collected for this study will be destroyed after the end of my degree.

Section 2.4 Analysis of social media data

Answer the following questions:

What information will you gather using this analysis of social media data?
Answer- Brand communications about virtual events and campaigns on the Metaverse and users reactions and comments.

Which data will you select from each of the platforms you research?
Answer-
Instagram: brand communications and marketing messages, influencer blogs and reviews, user-generated feedback and comments, and all Metaverse event advertising content. Visual and Content analysis.
YouTube: Video content analysis about the Metaverse.

LinkedIn: brand communications and marketing messages, influencer blogs and reviews, user-generated feedback and comments, and all Metaverse event advertising content. Visual and Content analysis.
Facebook: brand communications and marketing messages, influencer blogs and reviews, user-generated feedback and comments, and all Metaverse event advertising content. Visual and Content analysis.

What will be the time period from which data will be taken?
From 01/2020 to 09/2023

Please read the following statements carefully and tick all boxes to confirm that you have understood

☑ I confirm that I have read the instructions and restrictions for the analysis of social media data and that my research project will conform with these.
☑ Only I will have access to the non-anonymous data
☑ Only I and my supervisor will have access to the anonymized data
☑ I understand that if I lose personal data, I must contact databreach@soton.ac.uk immediately.
☑ I will use the University of Southampton's OneDrive as the only data storage for all data gathered during the research.
☑ Data collected for this study will be destroyed after the end of my degree.

SECTION 3

Checklist: Forms and documents attached to this submission. Tick relevant boxes and add your methods.

☑ I have included completed recruitment texts for the following research methods: Interviews.
☑ I have included completed participant information sheets for the following research methods: Interviews
☑ I have included completed consent forms for the following research methods: Interviews
☑ I have included interview questions (delete as appropriate).
☑ I confirm that any participant-facing documents in a language other than English have been carefully checked for grammar and spelling errors by someone fluent in the relevant language. (This may be the researcher or a third party.)

SECTION 4 DECLARATIONS

DECLARATION A

For all projects using human participants or social media methods which fall within the module level guidance and its restrictions

☑ I confirm that this form is an accurate record of the research that is planned, and that the research I do for my final project will not deviate from this plan.
☑ I am aware that it is a breach of the academic integrity regulations to conduct research on either humans or their data without the appropriate approval, and that the penalties for such a breach can include the termination of my degree.

Student's declaration:

I have discussed my research methods with my supervisor. All of the necessary documents have been given to my supervisor, and they accurately reflect the research that I will do. I understand that if I later wish to make any changes then I must consult my supervisor and provide updated versions of the relevant documents before changing how I do the research.

Signature: Sakshi Khadgi Date: 16/06/2023

Supervisor's declaration:

I have discussed this research methods with the student, received and checked all of the required forms and added them to the Sharepoint site for the module.

Any further comments:

Supervisor name:

Email: Date:

Appendix 4 : Interview Questions – 30mins – 45mins

- Collect participant Demographic information -
- Explain the research project – aim, objectives and research questions
- Explain how the interview process will happen.
- Prepare some examples to show them – from the fashion brands
- Prepare some definitions – meaning

- How would you define the **metaverse** in the context of **fashion marketing**, and what potential opportunities does it offer for brands to shape and enhance their brand image?
- (Why do you think the brand you are working for not engage in Metaverse or Virtual activities? Do you think they should be? Are you aware of fashion brands using the metaverse?)
- In your opinion, how does fashion marketing in the metaverse differ from **traditional marketing channels** in terms of its impact on **brand image**?
- What **challenges** do fashion brands face when using the metaverse for marketing, and how do these challenges affect their brand image? How can these challenges be addressed or mitigated?

- How does **virtual fashion** and the presence of **virtual influencers** in the metaverse impact **brand image** for fashion brands? Are there any specific considerations that fashion brands should keep in mind when engaging with virtual fashion and influencers?
- How can fashion brands leverage **user-generated content** in the metaverse to shape and enhance their brand image? Are there any risks or challenges associated with this approach?
- With the rise of metaverse platforms, how important is it for fashion brands to establish a **unique and recognizable visual identity** in the virtual environment? What **metrics or indicators** should fashion brands consider when evaluating the impact of their marketing efforts in the metaverse on brand image? Are there any **specific analytics tools or platforms** that you would recommend?
- What **ethical considerations** should fashion brands keep in mind when engaging in marketing activities in the metaverse? How can brands ensure they are promoting **inclusivity, diversity, and responsible practices** in these virtual environments?

Appendix 3 : Transcripts and consent forms

Appendix 4 : FETUS.pdf

Appendix 5 : brand case study (1).pdf

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